

THE GOSPEL ACCORDING TO JOHN

John 2

Jesus Reveals His Glory and His Authority

Purpose of This Study

To observe carefully what John records, understand what the signs reveal about Jesus Christ, and respond with faith, obedience, reverence, and a life centered on Him.

Key Verse

"This, the first of his signs, Jesus did at Cana in Galilee, and manifested his glory. And his disciples believed in him." - John 2:11 (ESV)

Big Idea

Jesus is the divine Son who brings the joy and cleansing people cannot provide for themselves. His signs reveal His glory, and His authority demands a sincere response of faith.

Chapter Outline

- John 2:1-12 - Jesus turns water into wine at Cana.
- John 2:13-22 - Jesus cleanses the temple and identifies His body as the true temple.
- John 2:23-25 - Jesus knows what is truly in every person.

Context

John 1 introduces Jesus as the eternal Word, the Lamb of God, the Messiah, the Son of God, and the Son of Man. John 2 begins the public revelation of His glory through signs. The chapter moves from a wedding celebration to the Jerusalem temple, showing that Jesus has authority in both ordinary life and sacred worship.

John 2:1-2 - Jesus Is Invited to a Wedding

Read: A wedding is held at Cana in Galilee. Mary is there, and Jesus and His disciples are invited.

Observation - What does the text say?

John names a real place, a real occasion, and real participants. Jesus does not withdraw from normal human life; He enters a family celebration with His disciples.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The eternal Word who became flesh is present in ordinary community life. His presence at the wedding honors marriage and shows that holiness is not separation from every human celebration, but faithful participation under God's rule.

Application - How should we respond?

Invite Christ's rule into ordinary relationships, celebrations, and decisions. Do not divide life into 'spiritual' and 'unspiritual' compartments.

Scripture support

- Genesis 2:18-24 - God establishes marriage.
- Hebrews 13:4 - Marriage is to be held in honor.
- Colossians 3:17 - Do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus.

John 2:3-5 - Mary Brings the Need to Jesus

Read: When the wine runs out, Mary tells Jesus. Jesus answers that His hour has not yet come. Mary tells the servants, 'Do whatever he tells you.'

Observation - What does the text say?

The shortage threatens embarrassment for the family. Mary identifies the need, but Jesus makes clear that His mission and timing are governed by the Father, not by human pressure.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

Jesus' words are respectful but corrective. In John's Gospel, 'the hour' points ultimately to His death, resurrection, and glorification. Mary responds well: she does not control Jesus; she directs the servants to obey Him.

Application - How should we respond?

Bring needs honestly to Jesus, submit to His timing, and obey what He has revealed. Faith trusts His wisdom even before the answer is visible.

Scripture support

- John 7:6-8 - Jesus acts according to the Father's timing.
- John 12:23-27 - His hour is connected to the cross and glorification.
- Luke 1:38 - Mary models humble submission to God's word.
- Philippians 4:6 - Bring requests to God with prayer and thanksgiving.

John 2:6-8 - The Servants Obey Jesus

Read: Six stone jars used for Jewish purification stand nearby. Jesus commands that they be filled with water, then tells the servants to draw some out and take it to the master of the feast.

Observation - What does the text say?

The jars could hold a very large amount. John connects them with ceremonial purification. The servants fill them completely and obey before knowing what Jesus will do.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The sign uses the setting of old purification practices to point toward the greater cleansing and abundance found in Christ. Jesus works sovereignly, yet the servants participate through simple obedience.

Application - How should we respond?

Obey Christ fully, not partially. Our responsibility is faithfulness to His command; the result belongs to Him.

Scripture support

- Mark 7:3-8 - Jewish purification customs could become external traditions.
- Hebrews 9:9-14 - Christ provides cleansing that outward regulations cannot accomplish.
- James 1:22 - Be doers of the word.
- Ephesians 3:20 - God is able to do beyond what we ask or think.

John 2:9-10 - Jesus Provides Abundantly

Read: The master tastes the water that has become wine. He does not know its source, but the servants know. He tells the bridegroom that the good wine has been kept until now.

Observation - What does the text say?

The transformation is complete, immediate, and of excellent quality. Jesus quietly protects the family from shame and provides more than a minimal solution.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The sign displays the creative power and generous goodness of Jesus. The best has arrived in Him. John's emphasis is not indulgence, but the identity and glory of the One who performed the sign.

Application - How should we respond?

Trust Christ as the sufficient provider. Remember that His gifts should lead us to worship the Giver rather than merely enjoy the gift.

Scripture support

- Psalm 104:14-15 - God's provision brings gladness.
- Isaiah 25:6-9 - God's saving banquet pictures abundant joy.
- John 10:10 - Jesus gives abundant life.
- James 1:17 - Every good gift comes from above.

John 2:11-12 - The First Sign Reveals His Glory

Read: John calls this the first of Jesus' signs. It manifests His glory, and His disciples believe in Him. Jesus then travels to Capernaum with His mother, brothers, and disciples.

Observation - What does the text say?

A sign is a miracle that points beyond itself. The purpose is revelation: Jesus' glory becomes visible and the disciples' faith deepens.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

The sign echoes the glory of the eternal Word in John 1:14. Biblical faith is not blind; it responds to God's self-revelation in Christ. Yet the disciples' understanding will continue to grow.

Application - How should we respond?

Read the signs in John's Gospel by asking, 'What does this reveal about Jesus?' Let every discovery move you toward deeper trust and worship.

Scripture support

- John 1:14 - The disciples behold the glory of the Word made flesh.
- John 20:30-31 - The signs were written so readers may believe.
- 2 Corinthians 3:18 - Believers are transformed as they behold the Lord's glory.

John 2:13-17 - Jesus Cleanses His Father's House

Read: At Passover, Jesus goes to Jerusalem. He finds merchants and money changers in the temple courts, drives them out, and commands that His Father's house not be turned into a house of trade. The disciples remember Psalm 69:9.

Observation - What does the text say?

Animals and currency were connected to worship, but commerce had overtaken the sacred purpose of the temple. Jesus acts deliberately and authoritatively, not from uncontrolled temper.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

By calling the temple 'my Father's house,' Jesus makes a unique claim about His relationship with God. His zeal fulfills Scripture and exposes worship corrupted by selfish gain.

Application - How should we respond?

Examine whether convenience, profit, appearance, or habit has displaced genuine worship. Approach God with reverence and let Christ cleanse what dishonors Him.

Scripture support

- Psalm 69:9 - Zeal for God's house consumes the righteous sufferer.
- Isaiah 56:7 - God's house is to be a house of prayer.
- Jeremiah 7:9-11 - God condemns false worship and exploitation.
- 1 Corinthians 6:19-20 - Believers are temples of the Holy Spirit.

John 2:18-22 - Jesus Is the True Temple

Read: The leaders demand a sign proving Jesus' authority. Jesus answers, 'Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.' They think He means the building, but John explains that He speaks about His body. After the resurrection, the disciples remember and believe.

Observation - What does the text say?

The leaders focus on the forty-six-year temple project. Jesus points instead to His coming death and resurrection. Their demand for proof is answered with the greatest sign of all.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

Jesus is the true meeting place between God and humanity. The temple building will not be the final center of God's presence; the crucified and risen Son is. His resurrection validates His authority and His words.

Application - How should we respond?

Center worship, access to God, and hope on the risen Christ. Allow later fulfillment and the whole of Scripture to clarify difficult sayings of Jesus.

Scripture support

- Matthew 12:38-40 - Jesus points to His resurrection as the decisive sign.
- John 1:14 - The Word 'dwelt' among us, revealing God's presence.
- John 14:6 - Access to the Father is through Christ.
- 1 Peter 2:4-5 - Believers become a spiritual house through Christ.

John 2:23-25 - Jesus Knows Every Heart

Read: Many people believe in Jesus' name when they see His signs, but Jesus does not entrust Himself to them because He knows all people and knows what is in a person.

Observation - What does the text say?

Their response is attracted to miracles, but Jesus sees beneath public enthusiasm. The same Greek verb is used for their 'believing' and Jesus not 'entrusting' Himself to them, highlighting the difference between fascination and dependable faith.

Interpretation - What does the text mean?

Jesus possesses divine knowledge of the human heart. Outward profession alone does not prove spiritual life. The next chapter introduces Nicodemus and explains the need to be born again.

Application - How should we respond?

Ask whether your faith rests on who Jesus is or only on what you hope He will do. Come honestly before the One who already knows your motives.

Scripture support

- 1 Samuel 16:7 - The Lord looks on the heart.
- Jeremiah 17:9-10 - God searches and tests the heart.
- John 6:26-29 - Some seek Jesus mainly for material benefit.
- Hebrews 4:12-13 - Every heart is exposed before God.

Major Truths in John 2

1. Jesus Reveals Divine Glory

The miracle at Cana is a sign pointing to Jesus' identity. His creative power, goodness, and abundance reveal the glory of the Word made flesh.

2. Jesus Acts on the Father's Timetable

Human need matters to Him, but His mission is governed by the Father's will and moves toward the cross and resurrection.

3. Jesus Has Authority Over Worship

He identifies the temple as His Father's house, confronts corruption, and establishes Himself as the true temple.

4. Jesus' Resurrection Is the Decisive Sign

The resurrection explains and validates His identity, authority, and words.

5. Jesus Knows the Human Heart

He distinguishes genuine discipleship from temporary excitement based only on impressive signs.

Key Words and Ideas

Term	Meaning in John 2
Sign	A miracle that reveals Jesus' identity and glory; it is meant to lead to faith, not merely amazement.
Hour	The divinely appointed time of Jesus' death, resurrection, and glorification.
Glory	The visible revelation of Jesus' divine identity, character, and power.
Temple	First the Jerusalem sanctuary, then interpreted by Jesus as His own body - the true place of God's presence.
Believe	A response that may be shallow or genuine; John calls readers toward enduring trust in Jesus Himself.

Personal and Group Application

Use these questions for prayer, journaling, or group discussion.

- Where do I need to bring a genuine need to Jesus while submitting to His timing?
- What command of Christ do I already understand but still need to obey fully?
- Am I seeking Jesus Himself, or mainly the benefits I want from Him?
- Has convenience, habit, appearance, or personal gain weakened my worship?
- How does the resurrection strengthen my confidence in Jesus' words and authority?
- What does my response to Jesus reveal about the condition of my heart?

Discussion Questions

- Why does John call the Cana miracle a sign rather than merely a miracle?
- What do Mary's words, 'Do whatever he tells you,' teach about discipleship?
- What is the relationship between the purification jars and the better provision Jesus brings?
- Why was Jesus justified in cleansing the temple?
- How does Jesus' body replace the temple as the center of God's presence?
- What is the difference between sign-based enthusiasm and saving faith?

Suggested Teaching Plan (45-60 Minutes)

Time	Teaching Movement
5 min	Opening prayer, chapter setting, and the big idea.
15 min	John 2:1-12 - Walk through the Cana sign: need, obedience, provision, glory, and faith.
15 min	John 2:13-22 - Explain Jesus' zeal, authority, true-temple claim, and resurrection sign.
8 min	John 2:23-25 - Contrast outward excitement with genuine trust.
10 min	Application and discussion: obedience, worship, motives, and faith.
5 min	Summary, gospel connection, and closing prayer.

Gospel Connection

The shortage at Cana and the corruption in the temple expose human insufficiency. Jesus supplies what people cannot create, cleanses what sin has corrupted, and gives access to God through His death and resurrection. The proper response is not mere amazement but repentance and faith in Him.

Final Review and Prayer

Before ending the study, review what John 2 reveals about Jesus and identify one response of faith.

What John 2 Reveals About Jesus

- He is the glorious Son whose signs reveal His identity.
- He provides abundantly and transforms what people cannot change.
- He acts according to the Father's will and appointed time.
- He has authority to cleanse worship and judge the human heart.
- His death and resurrection establish Him as the true temple and the way to God.

My Response

One truth about Jesus I need to remember:

One step of obedience I will take:

One person with whom I can share this truth:

Closing Prayer

Lord Jesus, reveal Your glory through Your Word. Teach us to trust Your timing, obey Your commands, worship with reverence, and rest our faith in Your death and resurrection. Search our hearts and form in us a sincere faith that glorifies You. Amen.

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